

Dan Mercede

Operator first, then builder. AI workflows with clear ownership, from the first working version to the checks that keep them running.

BIO

Dan Mercede spent four years as a General Manager with full P&L ownership, and fifteen years before that in sales and financial operations at Apple, Diageo, and Nestlé USA. Running a business showed him where automation breaks: nobody owns the workflow, so nobody notices when it drifts.

He now builds AI systems around that problem. He operates a private AI control plane that has run continuously for months on a self-managed cluster, and publishes the reusable parts as open-source tools, including failclosed, schemafit, and mcp-context-budget.

UPCOMING

NODES 2026 by Neo4j · November 12, 2026

Don't Flatten the Tree: Ingesting Branched Conversations into a Knowledge Graph

Speaker page: <https://neo4j.com/nodes/speakers/dan-mercede/>

RECOGNITION

Finalist, UiPath AgentHack 2026 (Track 3, UiPath Test Cloud), for Proctor, behavioral regression testing for AI agents.

TALKS

- **Who owns the workflow?**

Why AI pilots stall after a good demo, and five tests that separate a demo from a workflow a business can depend on.

- **Fail closed by default**

Merge admission for AI-written code: distrust the reviewer's output, refuse to merge on anything ambiguous, and prove the gate fires.

- **Don't flatten the tree**

Ingesting branched LLM conversation history into a production knowledge graph without losing branch identity.

- **Agents inside a context budget**

Keeping tool surfaces and web access from eating a coding agent's context window.

FORMATS

Conference talks, meetups, podcasts, and virtual sessions. Screen-share demos of running systems where the format allows.